

Inked Oracles

In this category, delegates will explore how perspective shapes the way stories are told and remembered. Delegates will be evaluated on their ability to combine historical understanding, literary technique, research, creativity, and critical interpretation while maintaining continuity across the two rounds. The category will test research, literary analysis, creativity, adaptability, and the ability to construct compelling perspectives.

ROUND 1: THE RECORD

Delegates will be assigned a historical event, drawn at random from a curated pool of events. Events will not be disclosed before the round. Each delegate will then draw either a

Victory stance — representing the dominant, victorious, or powerful side

Loss stance — representing the defeated, oppressed, or disadvantaged side

Delegates will receive their assignment on the day and will be given time to research the event before writing.

Delegates must write the event from the perspective of someone belonging to their assigned side. Possible perspectives include but are not limited to:

- A soldier
- A government official
- A wealthy landowner
- A journalist
- A victorious general
- A civilian
- A political leader
- An eyewitness

The form allows for complete creative freedom. Delegates may choose from the following:

- Diary entry
- Letter
- Monologue
- News report
- Prose piece
- Poem
- Speech

Delegates cannot explicitly reveal the given stance. Instead, power and perspective must emerge through:

- Language
- Tone
- Assumptions
- Description
- What the narrator chooses to emphasise
- What the narrator deliberately or unknowingly omits

The goal is not simply to recount the event, but to demonstrate how the person telling the story shapes the story itself.

Research:

Once their event and stance have been revealed, delegates will be given a designated period to research the event.

Research does not need to be extensive but should establish:

- Some historical context
- Social and political circumstances
- Perspectives surrounding the event

However, the final piece must remain the delegate's own interpretation and creative work.

TIME LIMIT: 1 HOUR 45 MINUTES

DELEGATE CAP: 2 PER TEAM

ROUND 2: THE ARTIFACT

Delegates will retain the same event and stance from Round 1. At the beginning of this round, each delegate will randomly draw an object from the Artifact Box.

Possible objects may include but are not limited to:

- A key
- A broken watch
- A photograph
- A shoe
- A receipt
- A newspaper
- A necklace
- A map
- An empty bottle

The Task:

Delegates must write a 300–500 word flash fiction piece exploring how their assigned object intersects with the event from Round 1. The piece should remain consistent with the perspective and world established in the first round.

The artifact must be essential to the story. It cannot simply be mentioned or inserted as decoration.

Delegates should consider:

- Why does this object matter?
- Who does it belong to?
- What does it reveal?
- How does it connect to the event?
- Does it carry personal, historical, or symbolic significance?
- Does it reveal something that the narrator of Round 1 did not?

The artifact may be interpreted literally or symbolically, but its significance must emerge naturally from the narrative.

TIME LIMIT: 1 HOUR 15 MINUTES

DELEGATE CAP: 2 PER TEAM

JUDGING CRITERIA:

1. Depth of Analysis

How effectively the delegate explores perspective, power, conflict, bias, and the implications of the event.

2. Research & Accuracy

Accuracy and effective integration of some relevant historical or contextual information.

3. Creativity & Interpretation

Originality of the response and the delegate's ability to transform the given material into an engaging literary piece.

4. Voice & Perspective

How convincingly the assigned perspective is established and maintained. The strongest responses will articulate their perspective with nuance, allowing the reader to discern the narrator's biases, assumptions, and understanding of the event without explicitly stating them.

5. Use of the Artifact

How meaningfully and naturally the assigned object contributes to the overall narrative.

NOTE: The time allocations, event pool, artifact pool, and specific requirements of each round may be altered at the sole discretion of the category heads. As historical events may require factual research, using reliable sources for historical information is permitted, however, submissions must be the participant's own original work. Any use of AI-generated text or copied material, will be considered plagiarism and will result in disqualification.